

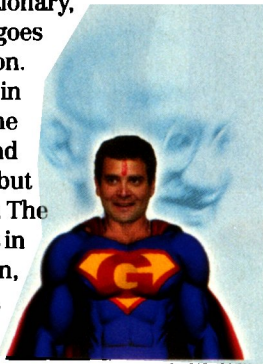
HORS D'OEUVRES DILIP BOBB

The Power of a Name



What's in a name? It's a clichéd question but the answer is that if it's the right name, it counts for a lot. Ask Kalawati, the impoverished widow from Vidarbha. Ten days ago, she was another grim statistic—her farmer husband had committed suicide under the burden of debt, her nine children had no present, no past, and no future. Then, Rahul Gandhi, in an inspired public moment, mentioned her in his Trust Vote speech and a miracle happened. Offers of help poured in and she will now get Rs 25,000 a month and education for her children. There are millions of Kalawatis in India but she became special because of a name: Gandhi. Anyone else who spoke that day could have mentioned her and her life would have stayed the same. Rahul is just a party functionary, but the power of a name often goes beyond performance and position.

The Gandhis are embedded in India's DNA. The original had the power of personal example and unquestioned moral superiority but he is now reduced to a metaphor. The Gandhi family, like the Kennedys in American popular imagination, are different. Like the Kennedys, tragedy has only enhanced their appeal, made them larger than life, and, despite a dubious record by those who occupied positions of power, they, including Sonia, an Italian by birth, remain a symbol of hope for millions of Indians.



SAURABH SINGH

Names with public resonance have usually been dynastic. In business, Tata has a privileged aura, greater than Birla or Singhania. Successive generations built that based on trust, transparency, nationalism and performance. When Ratan Tata launches the Nano saying "a promise is a promise", it is a uniquely Tata moment. The Ambanis are getting there in terms of a name transcending reality. The late Dhirubhai made the name synonymous with corporate success and the sons have inherited that legacy. Globally, outside business and politics, one name that has a magical appeal is the late Princess Diana. She married into royalty but her popularity was greater than any of the Windsor's. She also had a sordid private life but her name still sells books and newspapers. Like Diana, Rahul has a vulnerability and honesty of purpose that endears him to the public, despite lack of achievement. Humans subsist on hope, the belief that there is someone who will lead us out of darkness and create a better world. A name with established pedigree has a distinct advantage but it also helps if it comes easily on the tongue. Would Ratan Tata be as respected if his surname was Sodabottlewalla?



FIRE POWER: Muqtada Khan

Flaunting Their Clout

HYDERABAD The Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (MIM) seems to be bent on taking the law into its own hands. One of the five MIM legislators, Mohammed Muqtada Khan, fired in the air and another, Moazzam Khan, obstructed employees of the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation (GHMC) while they were pulling down an illegal floor as part of the demolition drive against unlawful constructions. The owner of the building, Mir Ahmed Ali, had allegedly constructed an additional floor without the permission of the GHMC and had encroached upon a portion of the main road.

Adding insult to injury, the legislators filed an attempt-to-murder complaint against GHMC's Chief City Planner Purushotham Reddy and two other employees. They also disrupted traffic for four hours, demanding immediate suspension of the GHMC officials.

Muqtada claims that he opened fire in self-

defence as the GHMC staff had attacked and roughed up Moazzam. The police slapped cases on the two MLAs for threatening GHMC officials, criminal intimidation and obstructing them from doing their job. Muqtada was booked for opening fire.

In August last year, the two were booked on many charges including rioting with deadly weapons, assault and criminal intimidation for the assault on writer Taslima Nasreen. Muqtada was also named as an accused in the attack on Zahed Ali Khan, the editor of Urdu daily *Siasat*, in March last year. "Is there no rule of law for the MIM? Or does the compulsion of vote bank politics make the Government afraid of acting against them?" asks former BJP chief M. Venkaiah Naidu. Meanwhile, the MIM, which has an MP and five MLAs, appears to be increasing its violent clout in Andhra Pradesh.

by Amarnath K. Menon